

Lesson 12: “The Gathering of My People” (See [Class Member Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To help us understand how latter-day Israel was gathered in the early days of the Church, how it is being gathered today, and how we can participate in this gathering.

1. The Lord is gathering His people.

“The gathering of Israel is a prominent theme in the Doctrine and Covenants. Anciently when the twelve tribes of Israel fell into apostasy, they were taken captive by their enemies and scattered among the nations of the earth, just as the Lord had warned. Although the prophets grieved over the wickedness of the people, they rejoiced as they foresaw the time in the latter days when Israel would be gathered again (see Topical Guide, “Israel, Gathering of”). This great process commenced with the restoration of the gospel and the calling of missionaries to “declare glad tidings of great joy unto this generation” (D&C 31:3).” (*Lesson Manual*) †1. The Prophet Joseph Smith

• 10th Article of Faith; D&C 45:71

Spiritual Gathering—“occurs as people learn the gospel, come unto Christ, are baptized into The Church of Latter-day Saints, and keep their covenants.” (*Lesson Manual*)

Physical Gathering—occurs as Church members gather in particular locations “or in the Stakes of Zion”. (*LM*)

• D&C 29:1-2, 7-8. †2. Elder Bruce R. McConkie

• D&C 110:11. †3. The Prophet Joseph Smith, r.e. priesthood and gathering

• D&C 33:7; 38:40; 39:11; 88:81. †4. President Spencer W. Kimball

2. The Saints gathered in Ohio.

“In December 1830, just eight months after the Church was organized, the Lord called the Saints to gather physically in Ohio.” (*Lesson Manual*, See Quad: Maps 3 and 6, or *Study Guide* pp 29, 31)

• D&C 38:31-32; 39:15 “endowed”

• D&C 95:8; 103:33; 110:9.

• D&C 38:24-27. Counsel from the Lord to those gathering in Ohio

• D&C 38:34-39. Further counsel

• *Our Heritage*: 16-23. (Sacrifices of the Saints delineated esp. on p. 23)

What could we learn today from their example?

3. The Saints gathered in Missouri.

• D&C 57:1-3 “A few months after the Saints began gathering in Ohio, Joseph Smith traveled to Missouri and received a revelation designating Missouri as the place for the city of Zion... From 1831 to 1838, the Church maintained centers of population in both Ohio and Missouri.” (*Lesson Manual*, See Quad: Maps 5 and 6, or *Study Guide*: Maps 2 and 3)

• *Our Heritage*: 37-39.

4. The Saints now gather to the stakes of Zion in their own lands.

“Church members maintained a strong presence in Ohio and Missouri from 1831 to 1838, when persecution forced most of them to leave. In 1839 they gathered in Illinois and established the city of Nauvoo. They were forced to leave Nauvoo in 1846, and in 1847 president Brigham Young led them to a new gathering place in the Rocky Mountains near the Great Salt Lake.” (*Lesson Manual*) (Quad: Map 6, or *Study Guide*: Map 3)

“For many years after the Saints settled in Utah, the call continued for Church members all over the world to gather to that area. However, that phase of the gathering has now ended, and Church members are counseled to gather to the stakes of Zion wherever they live.” (*Lesson Manual*) †5. Elder Boyd K. Packer: “The place of gathering....”

†6. President Spencer W. Kimball †7. President Ezra Taft Benson

What can we do to ensure that our stakes are a refuge and a defense against evil?

†8. President Harold B. Lee

The gathering of the Lord’s people continues today. Many of Heavenly Father’s children are searching for the truth, and “are only kept from the truth because they know not where to find it.” (D&C 123:12)

†9. Middle of Nowhere (An example of the spiritual nature of the modern gathering.)

What are some of our responsibilities to assist in this work?

Next Week: L 13: “This Generation Shall Have My Word through You”; See L13 [Class Member Study Guide](#).

(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).) † •

†1. **The Prophet Joseph Smith:** “All that the prophets have written, from the days of righteous Abel, down to the last man that has left any testimony on record for our consideration, in speaking of the salvation of Israel in the last days, goes directly to show that it consists in the work of the gathering.” (*Teachings of the Prophet Joseph Smith*, p. 83)

†2. **Elder Bruce R. McConkie:** “The purpose of the gathering of Israel is twofold: 1. To put the peoples of living Israel in that environment where they may better work out their salvation, where they may have the Gentile and worldly views erased from them, and where they may be molded into that pattern of perfect righteousness which will please the Almighty; and 2. To enable the gathered remnants of the chosen lineage to build temples and perform the ordinances of salvation and exaltation for their Israelitish ancestors who lived when the gospel was not had on earth.” (*Mormon Doctrine*, p. 306)

†3. **The Prophet Joseph Smith:** “It was the design of the councils of heaven before the world was that the principles and laws of the priesthood should be predicated upon the gathering of the people in every age of the world.” (*Teachings of the Prophet Joseph Smith*, p. 308)

†4. **President Spencer W. Kimball:** “I come to realize more and more, as my experience broadens, the vast influence and power that a small minority may wield in this world, in politics, in religion, in social activities, everywhere you go. A small group, united in purpose, with definite goals, may greatly influence the great majorities.” (*Teachings of Spencer W. Kimball*, p. 178)

†5. **Elder Boyd K. Packer:** “The place of gathering for the Mexican Saints is in Mexico; the place of gathering for the Guatemalan Saints is in Guatemala; the place of gathering for the Brazilian Saints is in Brazil; and so it goes throughout the length and breadth of the whole earth.... every nation is the gathering place for its own people.” (Quoted in *Church News*, 03/06/93)

“In April 1973, President Harold B. Lee quoted Elder Bruce R. McConkie in general conference. In doing so, he ‘in effect, announced that the pioneering phase of gathering was now over. The gathering is now to be out of the world into the Church in every nation.’” (Boyd K. Packer, “[To Be Learned Is Good If...](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1992, 71)

†6. **President Spencer W. Kimball:** “There is good reason for members of the Church who are isolated from the stakes and their benefits that they may wish to consider moving to central places, where all the blessings of the Church are available. Sometimes, of course, that is not feasible, and so we remain in the outskirts and build up the Church wherever we are.... Migration to America is not necessary any longer.” (Quoted in *Answer To Your Questions About the Doctrine and Covenants*, pp. 43-44)

†7. **President Ezra Taft Benson:** “Presently, Israel is being gathered to the various stakes of Zion.... A stake has at least four purposes:

“1. [Stakes are] to unify and perfect the members who live in [their] boundaries by extending to them the Church programs, the ordinances, and gospel instruction.

“2. Members of stakes are to be models, or standards, of righteousness.

“3. Stakes are to be a defense. They do this as stake members unify under their local priesthood officers and consecrate themselves to do their duty and keep their covenants....

“4. Stakes are a refuge from the storm to be poured out over the earth.” (“[Strengthen Thy Stakes](#),” *Ensign*, Jan 1991, pp. 2, 4-5)

†8. **President Harold B. Lee:** “The Lord has placed the responsibility for directing the work of gathering in the hands of the leaders of the Church to whom he will reveal his will where and when such gatherings would take place in the future. It would be well—before the frightening events concerning the fulfillment of all God’s promises and predictions are upon us, that the Saints in every land prepare themselves and look forward to the instruction that shall come to them from the First Presidency of this Church as to where they shall be gathered and not be disturbed in their feelings until such instruction is given to them as it is revealed by the Lord to the proper authority.” (*Conference Report*, Apr 1948)

†9. **Middle of Nowhere (An example of the spiritual nature of the modern gathering.):** Elder Parra served as a missionary in southern Mexico in 1961. The trains he and his companion rode through the mountainous jungles were steam-driven locomotives and occasionally stopped in isolated places to take on water from elevated water tanks.

On one trip, when the train stopped to take on water for the boilers, Elder Parra wakened his gringo companion and pulled him off the train. As they watched the train disappear, it was 4:00 o'clock in the morning and there was not another village or person in sight. Elder Parra's companion exclaimed, "It's the middle of the night, and we're in the middle of nowhere, and there won't be another train until tomorrow morning!"

Elder Parra said, "I know, but the Spirit told me to get off."

His companion dropped his protests because he knew Elder Parra was close to the Lord. Elder Parra began walking into the mountains. They walked for seventeen miles until they came to a small village. Standing on a nearby hill, they pulled out their hymn books and sang until every curious villager had come.

Then they began to preach, and they preached half the day, then dammed up a small stream and baptized everyone of age in the village. Before they left, they ordained a villager to be an elder and then set him apart as president of that little branch. By hustling, they managed to catch the next day's train.

When the story was retold in a 1975 *New Era*, that little village was an active branch with about two hundred members. They had sent a missionary into the field and were working for their own chapel. The writer reported that Elder Parra was still in southern Mexico, serving as president of the Mexico Vera Cruz Mission, which led the church in baptisms while he presided over the mission. (Retold from: “[The Middle of Nowhere](#),” *The New Era*, May 1975, p.46)